

Self-Confidence

Something to Mull Over



Light, mirror, and a small mark becoming a question of source.

Wherever Noa entered, the room rearranged itself a little.

Not loudly. Not in a way anyone could be accused of. Only a tiny movement: a look that lingered half a second too long, a back straightening, a chair cleared faster than necessary, a smile arriving before there was a reason for it. People did not tell themselves they were doing it. Perhaps that was why it worked so well.

Noa knew.

Not because she was vain. Vanity requires distance. She knew the thing too closely. For years she had learned how beauty moves through the world like a key you never asked for, but which hangs around your neck anyway. Doors open. People soften. Small mistakes are forgiven. Silences receive elegant interpretations. Tiredness looks like depth. Restraint looks like confidence.

She was not foolish enough to deny it. She was not free enough to enjoy it.

At the office they sometimes called her, half joking, “the person you put in a room when the room needs to calm down.” She was good in meetings. Not only beautiful in them; genuinely good. She knew how to listen until the other side felt it had discovered for itself what she had said. She knew how to correct without humiliating. She could hold a presentation even when the numbers were not on her side.

Once, after a meeting with a particularly stubborn client, Roy told her, “You understand that when you tell people they are wrong, they feel complimented?”

Noa laughed. “Is that an accusation?”

“A superpower.”

She smiled because it was right to smile. She was a little pleased. She also felt the place inside where a compliment enters, touches a wall, and returns without lighting anything.

She did not speak about it. There was no sentence that would not sound ridiculous. How do you tell people that the world ranks you high and still you fall in a place nobody can see? How do you

explain that the problem is not that people fail to see you, but that they see too smooth a version of you, and that you almost believe them until you are alone with a mirror?

So Noa developed discipline. She knew which bathrooms had merciful light and which had cruel light. She knew which side of the table left part of the face in shadow. She knew how to be photographed only after the camera moved half a centimeter. She knew how not to look as if she knew. That was part of the talent: not only hiding the thing, but hiding the work invested in hiding it.

Most of the time it worked.

Then, on a Tuesday, they asked to photograph her for a professional article. The article was about the campaign she had led, but everyone in the office spoke about the photograph. "It matters for branding," the CEO said. "Ours and yours." Noa said of course. She was good at "of course." It is a word that lets a person agree before fear has time to arrive.

The photographer came in the morning with a black shirt and a suitcase full of lenses. He did not praise her out loud, and for that she gave him points. People who admired too early made her feel they had already decided what she was allowed to be.

"We'll stand by the window," he said. "The light is good there."

The light there was too good. It did not blur. It did not flatter out of laziness. It showed.

After several shots she asked for a break and went to the bathroom at the end of the corridor. Not the one with yellow light. Not the wide one. For some reason, the third one - the one that did not know how to lie.

There, before the mirror, she opened her bag. The concealer was small, almost absurd compared with the power she had given it. A light plastic cylinder, a silver cap, a three-centimeter promise: what disturbs can be smoothed. The face can be returned to the version the world knows how to love without reservation.

She held it in her hand.

Above the cheekbone, near the left eye, was the mole. Small. Clear. Not an illness. Not a deformity. Not a disaster. A dermatologist had once said it was fine. A makeup artist had once said, "Don't cover it, it gives character." Noa smiled then as one smiles when someone gives something yours too beautiful a name, and you know that refusing the name will make you look ungrateful.

She hated the word "character" in those moments. She hated "special" too. Most of all she hated "actually": actually beautiful, actually adds something, actually you.

Those words did not release her. They merely replaced the court. Instead of needing to prove the thing disturbed her, others tried to prove that it contributed. Either way, she remained dependent on a verdict.

The concealer hovered above the skin. For a moment she imagined the photograph without the mark. Clean. Useful. Easy. She also imagined the photograph with it: not as bravery, not as manifesto, only as the refusal to let a small point on the face organize a whole life around itself.

She lowered her hand.

Nothing happened. No inner choir. No revolution. The face remained a face, not a lesson. She washed her hands though there was nothing on them, returned to the window, and stood where the light could find her.

"Ready?" the photographer asked.

"No," Noa said.

He lowered the camera.

She almost apologized. Then she did not.

"Take it anyway," she said.

The photograph that was published did not change her life. Some people said she looked wonderful. One person wrote that the image felt honest. She knew honesty was another word that could become a cage if praised too loudly. Still, for one small moment, the compliment entered, touched the wall, and stayed.